

The Infinite

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such watering holes as Las Vegas and Atlantic City, but she's become ordinary and predictable. What remains is her beauty—merely her beauty—without Ziegfeld's adoration and the gift of his transforming imagination. The Depression struck in 1929, Ziegfeld died in 1932, and a peculiarly American dream faded forever from view.

The Infinite

GIACOMO LEOPARDI

I always loved this solitary hill,
This hedgerow too, secreting from the view
So large a part of the far world's horizon.
But sitting here and gazing, in thought I conjure,
Beyond that hedge, the interminable tracts,
And silence more than man's, and peace so deep
The heart is all but daunted. And as I listen
To the wind at whisper in this foliage, so
That infinite silence to this very voice
I keep comparing, and there come to mind
Thoughts of *the eternal*, of old seasons dead,
And of ours now, vital, rife—the sound of it.
Amid this vastitude, all thought's awash:
And it's sweet to be lost in shipwreck on this sea.

English version by JOHN FREDERICK NIMS

✱ GIACOMO LEOPARDI (1798–1837), one of the most formidable linguists, thinkers, and scholars of his century, is one of the greatest of Italian poets. “L’Infinito” (1819) is probably his best-known poem. JOHN FREDERICK NIMS’s most recent books of poetry are *The Six-Cornered Snowflake* and *Zany in Denim*. The enlarged third edition of his *Sappho to Valéry: Poems in Translation* was published in 1990.